

US: EASTERN STATES

EXCELLENT HARBORS, FERTILE LAND, and rich mineral resources have made this region one of the most densely populated in the country. It was along the East Coast that the first settlers from Europe arrived in the 16th century. Today, the area includes some of the country's largest cities, such as New York and Washington, DC, as well as the once-great industrial centers of Chicago, Detroit, and Cleveland on the Great Lakes. Farther south, farmers use the land to cultivate cotton, tobacco, and vegetables grown for their oil. Hurricanes are a threat to people living on the Gulf and Atlantic coasts.



THE APPALACHIANS

The Appalachian Mountains run through North Carolina, Virginia, and West Virginia. For many years, coal was mined here and used to power steel mills. Today, many mines and factories have closed, eliminating jobs. Despite a plan to open up the area to tourists, Appalachia remains one of the poorest parts of the US.

The sign on this blues club in Memphis, Tennessee, is shaped like a giant guitar.

THE BIRTH OF THE BLUES

This part of the US is the birthplace of some of the world's most popular music. Jazz and blues were based on the spiritual and work songs of the black population. Country music began as poor white people's music in Kentucky and Tennessee, and the soul label Motown grew up in Detroit, the US.

Neon, used to light up so many buildings across America, was first invented in 1898.



BIG BUSINESS IN NEW YORK

Originally a fur-trading post at the mouth of the Hudson River, New York is now the US's financial capital. Wall Street, so called because it marked the line of the old city wall, is the home of the New York Stock Exchange. Financial deals worth billions of dollars are made there every day. Nasdaq, short for National Association of Securities Dealers Automated Quotation System, based in New York, was the world's first electronic stock market. Because it is a purely computer-based system, shares can be traded around the globe, 24 hours a day.



The White House has been the home of every US president since 1800.

RULING THE COUNTRY

The US has a written set of laws, known as a constitution, that sets out how the country should be governed. The center of government is Washington, DC, where the president and his family live in the White House. The president is the head of state and is chosen in elections that are held once every four years.



Flower buds form on the cotton plants.



Flowers turn pink and then fall off.



The cotton boll opens into a fluffy fiber ready for harvesting.

Cotton is woven into fabric for shirts, pants, and towels, which are sold at home and abroad.



This huge machine picks the cotton bolls from the plant.



COTTON – FROM FIELD TO FABRIC

In the mid-1800s, the southern states produced 80 percent of the world's cotton and grew rich on the profits. Cotton was grown on huge plantations, then handpicked by black slaves who had been brought by force from Africa. Slavery was finally abolished in the US in 1865. Cotton is still an important crop, although modern machinery now does the hard work. Soybeans, used mainly for oil, are now the biggest crop in this region.